

Eating for a visible jawline

Week 5 Lecture 2: Evidence-based looksmaxxing

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- Caloric balance: the arithmetic that determines body composition
- Protein intake: what the ISSN position stand actually says
- Cut, bulk, or recompose: when each approach fits your situation
- Hydration and sodium: what affects face appearance in the short term
- Realistic timelines: what ten weeks of consistent work delivers, honestly

By the end, you will be able to calculate your maintenance calories and protein target, and choose an appropriate approach for your situation.

Caloric balance

Energy balance determines body composition

Body composition changes follow a simple principle: eat fewer calories than you burn and you lose mass (mostly fat if protein is high); eat more and you gain mass (mostly muscle if training is consistent and protein is high).

- **Maintenance:** calories in = calories out. Weight is stable.
- **Deficit:** calories in below maintenance. Fat loss occurs. Muscle loss is minimized by high protein and resistance training.
- **Surplus:** calories in above maintenance. Mass gain occurs. Fat gain is minimized by a modest surplus and consistent training.

The size of the surplus or deficit determines the rate of change, but also the ratio of fat to muscle gained or lost.

How to estimate your maintenance calories

The Mifflin-St Jeor equation gives a reasonable estimate for most men.

$$\text{BMR} = (10 \times \text{weight in kg}) + (6.25 \times \text{height in cm}) - (5 \times \text{age in years}) + 5$$

Multiply BMR by an activity factor:

Sedentary (desk job, no exercise):	BMR × 1.2
Light exercise (1–3 days/week):	BMR × 1.375
Moderate exercise (3–5 days/week):	BMR × 1.55
Active (6–7 days/week, hard):	BMR × 1.725

A simpler approximation for a lightly to moderately active male: body weight in kg times 33. This is a starting point only. Track for two weeks and adjust based on actual weight change.

Choosing your approach

Three options based on your current situation.

Approach	Calorie target	Best fit
Recomposition	Maintenance or up to 200 kcal below	New to training, or returning after 6+ months off
Cut	300-500 kcal below maintenance	Trained for 1+ year, 5+ kg of excess fat
Lean bulk	200-300 kcal above maintenance	Trained for 1+ year, already lean, priority is muscle

Nippard (2020): "Body recomposition is most achievable for beginners and detrained individuals. The key variables are a modest caloric deficit, high protein, and consistent progressive resistance training."

Protein intake

What the ISSN position stand says

The International Society of Sports Nutrition reviewed the evidence for protein intake in exercising individuals (Jäger et al., 2017).

Their consensus: **1.4-2.0 g of protein per kg of body weight per day** is sufficient for maintaining and building muscle mass in most exercising individuals.

- At the lower end (1.4 g/kg): adequate for maintenance when in a caloric surplus
- At the upper end (2.0 g/kg): appropriate when in a deficit, recomping, or maximizing hypertrophy
- Distribution matters: 0.25 g/kg per meal (or 20-40 g absolute), spread over 3-4 meals

This is not a license to obsess over protein. Hitting the target consistently matters more than precision.

Practical protein sources

You do not need protein supplements to hit your target, though they are a convenient option.

- 100 g cooked chicken breast: approximately 31 g protein
- 2 whole eggs: approximately 12 g protein
- 170 g Greek yogurt: approximately 17 g protein
- 85 g canned tuna: approximately 20 g protein
- 100 g cooked lentils: approximately 9 g protein
- 30 g whey protein (one scoop): approximately 24 g protein

A 80 kg male targeting 144 g/day (1.8 g/kg) needs roughly four meals with 35 g protein each. This is achievable from whole food without tracking every gram if meals are structured around a protein anchor.

Body recomposition

Recomposition: losing fat and gaining muscle simultaneously

Recomposition is not a myth, but it has clear conditions. Nippard (2020) summarizes the research: simultaneous fat loss and muscle gain occurs most reliably in three populations.

- **Beginners** (less than one year of consistent training)
- **Returning lifters** (returning after 6+ months off, muscle memory active)
- **Individuals with significant excess body fat** (greater fat stores provide fuel for muscle protein synthesis even in a slight deficit)

If you are in one of these groups, a recomposition approach (maintenance calories, high protein, consistent progressive training) is the most practical starting point.

What recomposition delivers in ten weeks

Be honest with yourself about the timeline. Ten weeks of consistent work by an untrained male at maintenance calories with adequate protein produces:

- Measurable increases in strength (often 30-50% on key lifts for beginners)
- A modest reduction in body fat percentage (1-2 kg of fat loss is realistic)
- Visible changes in body shape that compound over months, not weeks

The jawline appears more defined not because bone changes, but because subcutaneous fat around the jaw and neck decreases when overall body fat drops. This takes more than ten weeks to become pronounced. Consistent habits over a quarter produce visible but not dramatic change.

Hydration and sodium

What you can and cannot control short-term

Face puffiness and water retention are real and partially controllable, but the levers are modest.

High-impact factors:

- Chronic high sodium intake causes the body to retain water subcutaneously, including in the face
- Alcohol causes significant water retention and bloating, visible in photos within 24 hours
- Sleep deprivation increases cortisol, which drives water retention (linking back to week 2)

Low-impact factors:

- Drinking more water on a given day does not cause face puffiness; it causes more urination
- Cutting carbohydrates reduces glycogen stores temporarily (glycogen binds water), but this reverses when carbs return

Minimum daily water intake: 35 ml per kg of body weight. The main benefit is avoiding chronic mild dehydration, not dramatic face changes.

Take-aways

1. Caloric balance is the primary lever for body composition. Estimate your maintenance, choose an approach, and track weight for two weeks to calibrate.
2. The ISSN recommends 1.4-2.0 g protein/kg/day. Aim for the higher end when cutting or recomping, distributed over 3-4 meals.
3. Body recomposition is realistic for beginners and returning lifters, but delivers visible changes over months, not weeks.
4. High sodium intake and alcohol cause short-term face water retention. Both are controllable habits.
5. Ten weeks produces measurable progress in strength and modest fat loss. Visible jaw definition takes a quarter of consistent work.

"For building and maintaining muscle mass, an overall daily protein intake in the range of 1.4-2.0 g protein/kg body weight/day is sufficient for most exercising individuals. Doses should ideally be distributed every 3-4 h."

Jäger R, Kerksick CM, Campbell BI et al., International Society of Sports Nutrition Position Stand: Protein and Exercise, 2017

What is next

- **Reading (due before section):** "Strength, protein, and body recomposition" at </c/looksmaxxing-26au/readings/wk05>
- **Section (this week):** Write your four-day program and nutrition plan, then peer review for compliance with the principles covered today
- **HW 3 out this week:** Strength program and nutrition plan (due Week 8)
- **Week 6 preview:** Dental, oral aesthetics, and the jawline conversation. Body recomposition concepts introduced this week are a prerequisite.